

Virginia Tech - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	A plausible seven-win, upper-middle ACC team with enough returning production and defensive-front talent to rebound sharply.
Preseason consensus	AP others receiving votes (6 points) · ACC media 8th (1,962 points) · SP+ No. 36
Returning production	69% (No. 5) overall · Off. 71% (No. 9) · Def. 67% (No. 8)
Primer power rating	+8.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.1 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better, with a wide variance band
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: HC James Franklin and OC Ty Howle build around an unresolved QB Ethan Grunkemeyer/QB Bryce Baker competition, WR Que'Sean Brown, TE Luke Reynolds and a still-forming OL.

Bottom line: Virginia Tech should improve sharply from 3-9, but poor 2025 efficiency and unresolved QB/OL/CB roles make the +8.5 rating a midpoint rather than a floor.

Beats expectations if: The new staff gets competent QB play, the OL settles, and DL Kemari Copeland, EDGE Nyck Harbor Fall and LB Noah Chambers lift a high-returning defense.

Disappoints if: The QB race lingers, the OL and CB pair fail to stabilize, and high returning production simply preserves too much of last year's inefficient roster.

Five things to remember

- ♦ **New staff:** James Franklin is the new head coach; Ty Howle is the offensive coordinator/play-caller and Brent Pry is the defensive coordinator/play-caller, so this is a major staff reset even with Pry remaining in the program.
- ? **QB question:** Quarterback remains unresolved between QB Ethan Grunkemeyer and QB Bryce Baker; QB Grunkemeyer brings seven late-2025 Penn State starts and 1,339 passing yards.
- Returning production:** Virginia Tech is No. 5 nationally in returning production, but the 2025 team ranked No. 101 in opponent-adjusted offense and No. 104 in opponent-adjusted defense.
- Defensive front:** DL Kemari Copeland is the defensive headliner, while WR Que'Sean Brown and TE Luke Reynolds are recognized offensive targets.
- Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No. 50 (6/10); the swing tier includes at Maryland, Pittsburgh, at California, Georgia Tech and Virginia, while Clemson/SMU/Miami form the highest-end tests.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	3-9 (2-6 ACC)	● Very poor
Scoring	21.4 PPG	● Poor
Total offense	348.8 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	182.4 YPG · 4.9 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	6.24 YPA · 17 TD / 9 INT	● Poor
Third downs	39.4%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	30.2 PPG allowed	● Poor
Total defense	378.1 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	153.2 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	224.8 YPG · 7.75 YPA · 18 TD allowed	● Poor

The 2025 offense was run-heavier than its overall quality: 182.4 rush yds/g ranked No.34, but scoring was No.113, total offense No.97 and pass efficiency No.112. The defense was also below the required level, allowing 30.2 pts/g (No.106) with pass-efficiency defense No.116.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-3.83 · No. 101	● Below average
Off. EPA/play	-0.007 · No. 69	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	41.3% · No. 90	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	12.9% · No. 49	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	16.3% · No. 87	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	-4.69 · No. 104	● Below average
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.095 · No. 109	● Poor
Def. success rate allowed	44.7% · No. 113	● Poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	13.1% · No. 106	● Poor
Havoc created	12.9% · No. 118	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: Virginia Tech had no hidden efficiency foundation in 2025: both opponent-adjusted units finished outside the top 100, while the defense struggled to get routine stops or create disruption. The rebuild therefore needs genuine improvement on both sides of the ball.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ James Franklin - from Penn State HC	● ↑ Raises the organizational/developmental ceiling; Year 1 transition adds uncertainty
OC / play-caller	◆ Ty Howle - from Penn State	● ↑ Familiarity with Franklin helps, but QB/OL roles must settle
DC / play-caller	◆ Brent Pry - returning program / new role	● ↔ Preserves program knowledge while changing responsibility

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Ethan Grunkemeyer	Penn State	● ↔ Material QB addition with seven 2025 starts, but the starting job is still unresolved.
◆ TE Luke Reynolds	Penn State	● ↑ Recognized Mackey candidate with prior production and a projected major role in the new offense.
◆ OL Justin Terry	Ohio State	● ↔ Early-camp first-unit left-tackle work gives him a material role in a line that remains unsettled.
◆ OL Logan Howland	Oklahoma	● ↔ Competes in the live tackle picture and adds needed depth/competition.

Out	To	Loss
QB Kyron Drones	Green Bay Packers rookie free-agent path	● ↔ Removes the experienced 2025 quarterback option and contributes to the 2026 QB reset.
OL Tomas Rimac	Minnesota Vikings UDFA	● ↓ Twelve starts and 788 snaps leave a direct continuity hole in an already unsettled line.
WR Isaiah Spencer	Ole Miss	● ↔ Five starts plus punt-return work represent material receiving/special-teams volume to replace.
WR Cameron Seldon	USF	● ↔ Twenty-three receptions plus return work make this a meaningful loss even if the new room has alternatives.
WR Donavon Greene	Left Virginia Tech during 2025 season	● ↔ Left Virginia Tech during the 2025 season; no transfer destination applies.

Offensive net: Better ceiling, but not yet a clearly better unit because quarterback and line certainty remain incomplete.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ CB Jaquez White	Troy	● ↔ A material candidate in a rebuilt corner room; role ordering remains open.
◆ CB Cam Chadwick Jr.	UConn	● ↔ Adds another credible option to the unresolved corner competition.
◆ LB Keon Wylie	Penn State	● ↔ Provides competition/rotation depth behind the new defensive staff.

Out	To	Loss
LB Caleb Woodson	Alabama	● ↓ Five starts and 58 tackles are meaningful second-level production to replace.
LB Michael Short	TCU	● ↔ Twenty-two tackles and four TFL in only four games made him a material contributor despite limited availability.
LB Jaden Keller	New York Jets signing	● ↔ Fifty tackles and six starts reduce experienced linebacker depth.
DL Kody Huisman	Buffalo Bills UDFA	● ↔ Thirty-eight tackles leave material front depth to replace.

Defensive net: Better projected structure at the top of the front, with enough linebacker/secondary turnover to keep the net effect closer to modest improvement than a wholesale leap.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	New Ty Howle offense built around an unresolved QB competition and transfer-supported skill group	WR Que'Sean Brown, TE Luke Reynolds and a deeper backfield	QB choice and final OL five must settle quickly
Defense	Brent Pry-led defense built around an experienced interior anchor and rebuilt second/third levels	DL Kemari Copeland and a clearer Mike role for LB Noah Chambers	2025 havoc was poor and the CB order remains unsettled
Special teams	Returning kicker with turnover elsewhere in the operation	K John Love provides the clearest specialist continuity	Punter and return-game roles are less settled after turnover

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B-	● ↑	Medium-low	QB Ethan Grunkemeyer has starting experience and QB Bryce Baker adds upside, but no QB1 is named.
RB	● B-	● ↔	Medium	RB Marcellous Hawkins returns and RB Bill Davis adds competition, but the room is not a proven league strength.
WR	● B-	● ↑	Medium-high	WR Que'Sean Brown anchors a deeper room after meaningful departures.
TE	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	TE Luke Reynolds is a Mackey-recognized transfer expected to play a major role.
OL	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	Transfer pieces provide options, but the final five remains unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	DL Kemari Copeland anchors a talented front that must improve a No. 118 havoc rate.
LB	● C+	● ↔	Medium	LB Noah Chambers stabilizes the middle after several material LB departures.
Secondary	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	S Tyson Flowers provides continuity, but the CB pair is rebuilt and unresolved.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Love returns at kicker, but punter and return-game roles are less settled after turnover.
Coaching	● B+	● ↑	Medium	HC James Franklin raises the ceiling, offset by Year 1 transition and new coordinator responsibilities.
Overall	● B	● ↑	Medium-low	The +8.5 rating and top-five returning production point to a bowl-plus roster.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Kemari Copeland	DL	● High-end conference defender / defensive fulcrum	ACC Preseason First Team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Outland	Best path to improving a defense that created too little havoc in 2025.
Que'Sean Brown	WR	● Lead-target / proven Power 4 receiving anchor	Biletnikoff	Most established target for whichever QB wins the job.
◆ Luke Reynolds (TR: Penn State)	TE	● High-upside transfer starter	Mackey	Major OC Ty Howle system piece with prior production.
◆ Ethan Grunkemeyer (TR: Penn State)	QB	● Starter candidate with prior Power 4 starting experience	-	Seven late-2025 starts give him the strongest starting résumé in the open race.
Bryce Baker	QB	● High-upside starter candidate	-	His competition with QB Ethan Grunkemeyer is the team's biggest unresolved variable.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Noah Chambers	LB	● Defensive communicator / projected Mike	-	Green-dot role can stabilize a LB room replacing several contributors.
Tyson Flowers	S	● Experienced back-end anchor	-	Best continuity point in a secondary with an unsettled CB order.
Marcellous Hawkins	RB	● Projected lead back / recognized returner	Doak Walker	Returning backfield piece while QB and OL roles settle.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	A middle-tier ACC schedule with enough toss-ups to reward rapid improvement, but three top-end tests limit transition margin.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Above average · SP+ SOS No. 50
Hardest stretch	at Clemson -> bye -> at SMU -> Stanford -> at Miami
Swing games	at Maryland, Pittsburgh, at California, Georgia Tech, Virginia
Advantage	VMI and Old Dominion open at home before the first Power 4 road game, giving the new staff a short runway.
Expected	7.1 wins · most likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Virginia Tech can become attractive if the market overweights the 3-9 record after the Franklin reset.
Back them when	The quarterback/OL configuration is stable, Virginia Tech owns a front-seven edge, and the opponent cannot punish a still-forming corner room.
Fade/pass when	The opponent can create pressure without blitzing, force obvious passing downs, or isolate the new corners before the Hokies prove down-to-down offensive efficiency.
Key monitor	QB1, final OL five, CB order, P Nathan Totten role, late availability
Week 1 baseline	vs. VMI: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Virginia Tech –50.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Virginia Tech has the returning production and staff upgrade to move well beyond 3-9, but the rebound still rests on unresolved QB, OL and CB roles. DL Kemari Copeland gives the defense a legitimate high-end anchor.

Seven wins is a sensible midpoint on a manageable ACC schedule. The upside rises if the new offense settles quickly; the floor remains lower than the aggregate continuity numbers suggest because 2025 efficiency was poor on both sides.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](#) · **Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026**

© 2026 DRWhittier. Original analysis, commentary, selection, and arrangement.

Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [fall camp](#) · [2025 stats](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [2025 Football Roster](#) · [Football Media Availability](#) [Tv Howle](#) · [Virginia Tech spring scrimmage reporting](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026